‘unofficial emissary and honest interpreter’ between Gandhi and the British from the 1930s. When the British began to grant Indians greater representation in government, Birla was instrumental in pushing the Congress to participate in elections and form provincial legislatures. He was also a frequent traveller between England and India, and met with British politicians and government officials to negotiate political measures that would satisfy both nationalist Indians and the colonial government. The reams of letters and documents that he wrote and that he is mentioned in testify to the central role he played in the movement.



Birla helped to negotiate the Poona Pact in 1932. Earlier that year, the British had offered separate electorates to Dalits, a move Ambedkar supported and Gandhi opposed. Gandhi began a fast unto death in protest, but Ambedkar refused to back down. The Poona Pact, which guaranteed reserved seats for Dalits, was the compromise that was reached. In later years, Ambedkar vehemently criticized the entire episode.

Builder of institutions

Birla understood that economic and social progress were as important to India as political freedom. He therefore spent much of his wealth on causes he believed in, especially education. In 1929, he set up the Birla Education Trust, which oversaw the establishment of several educational, scientific and research institutions in his birthplace Pilani. He also supported eminent